ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Complex embedding

Build and unpack multiple levels of complement, relative and adverbial embedding without losing clause boundaries or attribution. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use complex embedding to represent layered propositions while keeping each source, stance and logical relation identifiable while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Build and unpack multiple levels of complement, relative and adverbial embedding without losing clause boundaries or attribution.

MODEL

The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.

matrix clause + embedded complement + embedded modifier

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main complex embedding patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses represent layered propositions while keeping each source, stance and logical relation identifiable.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in research, law, policy analysis and complex narrative.

Build meaning before form

Build and unpack multiple levels of complement, relative and adverbial embedding without losing clause boundaries or attribution.

What complex embedding communicates

Build and unpack multiple levels of complement, relative and adverbial embedding without losing clause boundaries or attribution.

The central purpose is to represent layered propositions while keeping each source, stance and logical relation identifiable. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.	a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject
The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored.	two distinct layers of reporting responsibility
It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented.	an unresolved question containing its own modification

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: matrix clause + embedded complement + embedded modifier. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Complement plus relative	matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate	The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.
Nested attribution	source + report + second source + proposition	The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored.
Embedded interrogative	matrix stance + whether/wh + embedded clause	It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject	Complement plus relative
two distinct layers of reporting responsibility	Nested attribution
an unresolved question containing its own modification	Embedded interrogative

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in research, law, policy analysis and complex narrative. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
matrix clause	embedded complement	embedded modifier

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: represent layered propositions while keeping each source, stance and logical relation identifiable.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits research, law, policy analysis and complex narrative.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Complement plus relative	matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate	The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.
Nested attribution	source + report + second source + proposition	The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored.
Embedded interrogative	matrix stance + whether/wh + embedded clause	It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.	a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject
The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored.	two distinct layers of reporting responsibility
It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented.	an unresolved question containing its own modification

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not let a long relative clause obscure the verb of the embedded complement.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not blur which source is responsible for each proposition.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use direct-question inversion inside the embedded interrogative.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject?

OPTIONS The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient. · The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored. · It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: two distinct layers of reporting responsibility?

OPTIONS The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored. · It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented. · The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: an unresolved question containing its own modification?

OPTIONS It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented. · The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient. · The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject · two distinct layers of reporting responsibility · an unresolved question containing its own modification

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS two distinct layers of reporting responsibility · an unresolved question containing its own modification · a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS an unresolved question containing its own modification · a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject · two distinct layers of reporting responsibility

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Complement plus relative / Nested attribution / Embedded interrogative · Gap 2: a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject / two distinct layers of reporting responsibility / an unresolved question containing its own modification

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Nested attribution / Embedded interrogative / Complement plus relative · Gap 2: two distinct layers of reporting responsibility / an unresolved question containing its own modification / a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Embedded interrogative / Complement plus relative / Nested attribution · Gap 2: an unresolved question containing its own modification / a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject / two distinct layers of reporting responsibility

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject: _____. Choose the model that expresses two distinct layers of reporting responsibility: _____. Choose the model that expresses an unresolved question containing its own modification: _____. Choose the model built with matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate: _____. Choose the model built with source + report + second source + proposition: _____. Choose the model built with matrix stance + whether/wh + embedded clause: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented. · The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored. · The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The review concluded _____ the agency had introduced were insufficient. The paper notes that several _____ the warning was ignored. It remains unclear _____ the panel proposed can be implemented. State the full structural pattern for Complement plus relative: _____. State the full structural pattern for Nested attribution: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The agency introduced safeguards; the review found them insufficient.” using the Complement plus relative pattern to express a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The paper reports witness claims about an ignored warning.” using the Nested attribution pattern to express two distinct layers of reporting responsibility.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Implementation of the proposed changes remains uncertain.” using the Embedded interrogative pattern to express an unresolved question containing its own modification.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The agency introduced safeguards; the review found them insufficient.” using the Complement plus relative pattern to express a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Complement plus relative to express a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Nested attribution to express two distinct layers of reporting responsibility, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Embedded interrogative to express an unresolved question containing its own modification, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.

Complement plus relative is the best match because a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject.

A2

The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored.

Nested attribution is the best match because two distinct layers of reporting responsibility.

A3

It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented.

Embedded interrogative is the best match because an unresolved question containing its own modification.

A4

a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject

The Complement plus relative pattern communicates a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject.

A5

two distinct layers of reporting responsibility

The Nested attribution pattern communicates two distinct layers of reporting responsibility.

A6

an unresolved question containing its own modification

The Embedded interrogative pattern communicates an unresolved question containing its own modification.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Complement plus relative / a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject

The structure belongs to the Complement plus relative pattern. Its communicative purpose is a reported conclusion containing a modified embedded subject.

B2

Nested attribution / two distinct layers of reporting responsibility

The structure belongs to the Nested attribution pattern. Its communicative purpose is two distinct layers of reporting responsibility.

B3

Embedded interrogative / an unresolved question containing its own modification

The structure belongs to the Embedded interrogative pattern. Its communicative purpose is an unresolved question containing its own modification.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.

Complement plus relative: matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate.

C2

The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored.

Nested attribution: source + report + second source + proposition.

C3

It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented.

Embedded interrogative: matrix stance + whether/wh + embedded clause.

C4

The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.

Complement plus relative: matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate.

C5

The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored.

Nested attribution: source + report + second source + proposition.

C6

It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented.

Embedded interrogative: matrix stance + whether/wh + embedded clause.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

that the safeguards

Complement plus relative requires “that the safeguards” in this model. matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate.

D2

witnesses claim that

Nested attribution requires “witnesses claim that” in this model. source + report + second source + proposition.

D3

whether the changes

Embedded interrogative requires “whether the changes” in this model. matrix stance + whether/wh + embedded clause.

D4

matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate

Complement plus relative is built as matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate.

D5

source + report + second source + proposition

Nested attribution is built as source + report + second source + proposition.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.

matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended complement plus relative effect.

E2

The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored.

source + report + second source + proposition. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended nested attribution effect.

E3

It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented.

matrix stance + whether/wh + embedded clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended embedded interrogative effect.

E4

The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient.

matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended complement plus relative effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The review concluded that the safeguards the agency had introduced were insufficient. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses matrix verb + that + noun + relative clause + predicate accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The paper notes that several witnesses claim that the warning was ignored. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses source + report + second source + proposition accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

It remains unclear whether the changes the panel proposed can be implemented. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses matrix stance + whether/wh + embedded clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____